In protest against the imprisonment of its leaders, the NLD decided not to contest the 2010 elections.[12] Instead, they announced that they would promote democracy via a 'mass movement'[13] and carry on with their extra-parliamentary activities. One practical problem with this approach was that their activist core remained basically drawn from students. Their alliance with the Buddhist monks gave them a large constituency but this focus prevented them from being able directly to engage with and mobilise the potential political muscle of the workers or peasants. This has allowed the military to manage the threat of the NLD, and has left the opposition vulnerable to the specific interests of its two main constituencies.

In 2010 the NLD also attacked those elements of the pro-democracy movement that did decide to contest the elections. Not surprisingly, the elections were consequently won by the military-backed USDP, which claimed to have received 80 per cent of the vote:

4. 2010 Electoral Results[14]

National Parliament election results, 2010*

	USDP	*Ethnic*	*Pro-Democracy*	*National Unity Party*	*Independent*	*Cancel/ed*
People's Parliament (Lower House) 258		47	9	12	0	4
Nationalities Parliament (Upper House) 129		26	7	5	1	0

* The military appoints 25% of all seats to its soldiers: 56 additional seats in the Nationalities Parliament, 110 additional seats in the People's Parliament.

However, not only did the NLD boycott the 2010 elections but the USDP took a number of steps to boost its own notional support. Employees of state-owned enterprises, as well as civil servants, often voted en bloc and in advance of the notional polling date.[15] In effect, the USDP, even in the absence of its main rival, resorted to the crudest form of client voting[16] where by those who rely on the state for their livelihood are expected to vote for the party that provides them patronage.

The military junta was formally dissolved in 2011 and further by-elections were held in 2012 in forty-five constituencies. These were seen to have been much more fair than the elections in 2010; the NLD participated and won forty-three of the contested seats[17] (and 65 per cent of the popular